Chapter 14

She Is Enough

You can love your wife and struggle to name the last time you stopped to enjoy something about her. You could list what needs doing around the house without stopping to think. Ask yourself what you appreciate about her today, and you might need a minute.

That pause doesn't mean you don't care. You notice the appointment nobody made, the expense you weren't expecting, the habit that still annoys you. Your wife can become so familiar that you notice what bothers you about her faster than you notice her kindness.

The woman you love now.

My wife saves things I'd throw away. When the house feels junky, I've told her we live like hoarders. I think that sometimes hurts her feelings. There's a balance, and some things do need clearing out. Other times, what she kept is exactly what we need, and we don't have to buy it again. She has saved us a lot of money by reusing things and keeping them around.

"Hoarder" is the harsh word. The word I much prefer is thrifty. It's the same trait either way, and what I'm paying attention to picks the word. After a long stretch of nothing but work and family duty, every small thing is like nails on a chalkboard. My wife gets very anxious when we're late or things are behind schedule. That's just who she is, and I've learned to accept it. It can be annoying, but so can being late in her eyes.

She's getting gray hairs. She doesn't want other people to see them. I love them. She was a powerful attorney and a vice president at a public company. For about three years she's been on sabbatical, a break from her career, to be a

full-time mother. Her income has changed. Her body has changed. Mine has too. When she's working in the garden in shorts and a T-shirt, I find her incredibly attractive, and that's enough. She is enough for me.

I see her most clearly when I'm rested and have time with her as my friend. The other day we went to breakfast, with no kids and no deadline to race toward. We talked about the new house we're building, what my oldest son needs for college, and the chores we had that week. I noticed how nice it was to just be with each other and talk through shared goals.

Name something true about her, and stay with it long enough to remember why you value it. You don't need to improve her in your imagination before you can appreciate her in your life.

The plate in front of you.

My kids complain a lot about dinner. Then it's their turn to cook, and they find out how much work it is. They didn't appreciate what they had until they saw what it cost. In a 2014 classroom study, Froh and colleagues taught children aged eight to eleven to notice what a helper meant, what it cost and what it gave them. The children became more grateful. My wife cooks all the time, so she already knows what a meal costs. That's why she says the best meals are the ones you don't have to cook.

A meal someone made for you can be enough on its own. We see what we wanted and miss what went into it. I don't complain about dinner, because I've learned firsthand how hard her job is. That gave me perspective. Anything she makes is enough for me.

When enough keeps changing.

Spouses compare, husbands and wives both, often without noticing. On social media you see only what other people post, and you compare it piece by piece with your whole life. Life on the other side of the fence can look better. You meet someone who's funny, and suddenly your wife's humor is under review. Someone else catches your eye, and whatever you noticed becomes a new condition your wife has to meet. What you have starts to feel like it isn't enough.

Men tend to think a life beyond their wife is better. For some, maybe that's true. But many of them have never been with the woman of their dreams, so it's just a dream. Schkade and Kahneman found in 1998 that students in the Midwest and in California were equally satisfied with life, yet both groups expected Californians to be happier, because they fixed on the weather. Nobody asked them about marriage, but we do the same: we fix on the one thing someone else has, and let it decide the comparison.

It runs both ways. You'd want her to remember the whole of you, and she'd want the same from you. When either of you catches yourself comparing, you can say so kindly.

In Letter 16, the Roman Stoic Seneca wrote to his friend Lucilius: "Natural desires are limited; but those which spring from false opinion can have no stopping-point." You can put Seneca's test to what you want from her: can it stop at any definite point? If your wife met today's condition, would you let yourself enjoy her? Or would you find the next thing she lacks?

Your wife doesn't need to win another comparison before you treat her with affection.

Notice what you value.

The Stoic philosopher Marcus Aurelius offers a practice in *Meditations* VI.48: “When thou wishest to delight thyself, think of the virtues of those who live with thee.”

Give your mind an actual task: recall something worth being glad about.

This is the discipline of enough: practicing appreciation for the real person you’ve chosen. You don’t have to wait until you’re restless to begin.

Practice before you need it.

In a 2003 paper reporting three studies, psychologists Robert Emmons and Michael McCullough had people write down what they were grateful for. The people who listed them reported better well-being than comparison groups on several measures, though not all. It wasn’t a study of marriages, but it’s a reason to practice on purpose.

Before you go to bed, write down one thing you valued about your wife that day. Her patience with a child. Her excitement about something she’s learning. Choose what you actually noticed, rather than qualities a good wife is supposed to have.

If nothing comes to mind, you haven’t failed. Pay attention tomorrow. And if you’re upset with her, you don’t have to pretend the hurt disappeared. There may still be something you appreciate alongside it.

My family borrowed a gesture from the movie *Avatar*: a fingertip to the forehead and the words “I see you.” At every meal, I thank the kids and I thank her. I think the thanks can land as hollow, like an “I love you” said with nothing behind it. A quick thanks isn’t the same as appreciation.

Then let some of what you wrote down reach her. In 2019, Visserman and colleagues found in daily studies of couples that partners often missed each other's sacrifices, and the missed ones stirred no gratitude. Tell her what you saw and why it mattered to you. Be specific enough that she knows you paid attention. A wife who has stepped back from a career may miss feeling important, part of a team, or valued by peers. Hearing what you see in her can help.

You can also enjoy things about her that do nothing for you. You get to love a person whose life includes more than meeting your needs.

Let appreciation become care.

"The grass is greener where you water it" is a saying I keep coming back to. I don't know who first said it. It turns the old line about the other side of the fence around. Your attention and care are the water. What grows is your enjoyment of the woman already there. That can look like a kinder answer, a sincere compliment, or time spent enjoying her company. Keep doing that on ordinary days, before dissatisfaction makes it feel urgent.

Talk with her because you like talking to her.

None of this requires her to answer your affection on your schedule. If she's tired or distracted when you tell her, what you said is still true. You can be glad she's your wife and still feel hurt when you reach for her and hear no. What you decide is how to treat her while you feel it.

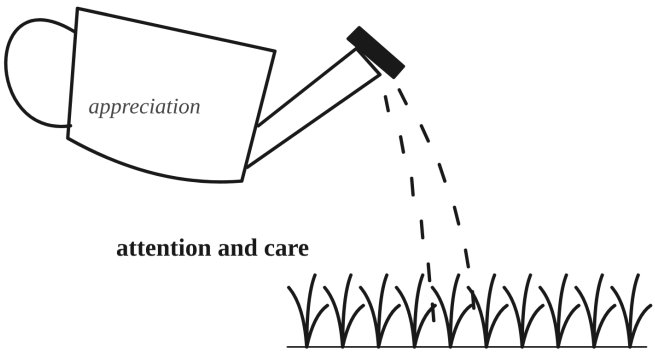
Contentment doesn't replace a conversation that needs to happen. If you'd still resent it two days later, it isn't small, and Chapter 11 covers what to do. You can love who she is while taking a problem seriously.

Most of your marriage happens in ordinary hours: a meal, a walk, a question about your day, the thing she saved that turns out to be exactly what you need. They don’t feel like much while you’re in them. They are the life you chose. Slow down enough to taste them.

Thankfulness is how you keep wanting what you already have.

Appreciation becomes care

Notice what you value in your wife



the woman already there

Chapter 15

Be Patient, Be Kind

Warmth is easy on a good day. It gets tested on the ordinary ones, when nobody is at their best.

Those days test it three ways. She's sharp with you. You're both fed up. A busy day pulls you apart. Each one has an answer: meet hostility with kindness, frustration with patience, and disconnection with warmth.

It usually starts small. She says something with an edge about the things that need doing, and before you've decided anything, your answer is already in your mouth.

Meet hostility with kindness.

My family has a word for that kind of comment. We call it a zing, and there are so many in a day it's hard to keep count. A zing is a little slight, a cutting remark. It's a critique, only small.

I didn't handle them well. Every little critique from her was met with an equal or escalated response. I had no patience, I didn't let things go, I wasn't kind. Frankly, neither was she.

Arguing styles drift over time, almost like evolution. You use what rewards. I'd feel tired. I'd feel frustrated that immediately she was giving me things to do. Her words felt like she was calling me lazy.

One kind of zing comes on Saturday mornings, on busy weekends. My wife wakes up with a jam-packed agenda for Saturday and Sunday to get a lot of things done. I'm tired and want to relax, or I'm just sitting down talking to the kids. She's asking for the status of things that need to be done. And sometimes

she'll say something like, "We don't have time to just lay around and not do stuff." Or: "There's an infinite amount of work to get done. Just look around. I shouldn't have to tell you what to do." You've probably heard your own version of those lines.

I used to take those lines personally. Over time I realized a line like that is more a sign of how stressed and overworked she is.

When you hear a line like that, you can ask one of two different questions. The first is about you. If it sounds like she's calling you lazy, ask yourself, "Is that truly the case?" If it is, fix it. If it isn't, let the remark go.

The second question is about her: what does the remark tell you about how she feels? Most of the time, the remark says less about you than it seems. It's an outward manifestation of how she's feeling on the inside. Maybe she isn't in a good mental state. Maybe she's frustrated about something. Either way, you don't have to be offended. That reading is for you to keep, not something to say to her. If a remark still hurts you every time, Chapter 11 covers how to raise it with her.

What changed for me came slowly, through experience. I started asking: who has the strength to de-escalate? Somebody has to be calm. Somebody has to be patient. Somebody has to be the one that's romantic and kind. Someone has to be the one that brings the warmth into the relationship.

In his study of anger, Seneca wrote: "Does a man get angry? Do you on the contrary challenge him with kindness. Animosity, if abandoned by one side, forthwith dies; it takes two to make a fight." (*De Ira* II.34, Basore trans.) "Forthwith" means at once. A zing rarely turns into a fight unless you send one back.

So instead of zinging her back, I do two things. I roll up my sleeves and start helping. Then I give her a hug, tell her what I see her carrying, and take a little time to find out if I can make her day lighter.

We have a saying in our house: “Never be the worst part of somebody’s day.” It’s a spot check, a way to make sure we’re not unkind. A sharper answer is the quickest way to be the worst part of her day.

Meet frustration with patience.

Feeling fed up drives faster responses and more intense reactions. You may know that from your own arguments. I know it from ours. The ironic part is that ours weren’t about any one topic. I was fed up with how we argued.

She gets fed up too, and on a weekend with a mountain of work ahead, so do you. When she’s tired, you may be tired too. That’s two tired people. Patience is your choice to be kind anyway.

Patience lives in the gap Chapter 1 named, between her remark and your reply. Seneca put it in one line: “The best corrective of anger lies in delay.” (*De Ira* II.29, Basore trans.) You don’t have to answer in the first second. You can roll up your sleeves first.

Answering every zing is checkers. Chess means keeping your eye on the long game. When I let the zings go and give her kindness instead, it has an incredible impact on changing the tone and the mood of the entire house. I would rather have a good night of happiness with my wife than try to answer each exchange. You get to decide which of those you’re after. I tell people, “Would you rather be right? Or would you rather be married?”

None of this is surrender. Letting a zing go doesn’t mean doing whatever she says. This is my own advice to myself, learned through experience. It comes down to Chapter 1’s question, asked in the moment: Are you being the best husband possible right now, at this moment, irrespective of what she is doing?

Meet disconnection with warmth.

Disconnection often happens when everyone is busy and there's nothing but a mountain of work ahead of you. It gets even worse when other family members have friction between them. If my wife is frustrated with one of her siblings on the phone, or with one of our children, that then leads to disconnection with us. Sometimes I have to see that as not a verdict on me, just a sign that she is feeling strained. Whenever I take the bait, I add another layer, and then everybody's pulled into the vortex.

Warmth is how you stay out of the vortex and pull her out of it. You can be home all weekend and still not be kind. As I see it, being kind is different than just being there. It's trying your best to make someone's day better.

For me, that's a foot rub when she's had a long day. It's taking over a chore that's usually hers. It's letting her talk about her day, because it's a kindness to let her speak and get things off her chest.

Why is the chore kind? It's an act of service, her love language. And it's kind because these are normally things that she does, and I'm taking chores and work off of her plate. I'm doing something that shows I want to make her life better. You know which chores are usually hers in your house.

A 2022 study by Gordon and colleagues looked at housework. People who did more of it, and felt the split was unfair, tended to be less satisfied in the relationship. The exception was people who felt appreciated by their partner. The study wasn't about husbands who help, but I read it as a reason for you to do both: help her, and let her know you see her.

When you are the sun, people come to you to feel good. In Book I of *Meditations*, the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius lists what he learned from the people who shaped him. Sextus is one of them. Marcus wrote that Sextus "never showed anger or any other passion, but was entirely free from passion, and also most affectionate." (*Meditations* I.9, Long trans.) The Greek behind

“most affectionate” belongs to the word *philostorgia*, family love. “Free from passion” here means Sextus wasn’t ruled by anger or upset. Sextus was calm and warm at once.

That pairing is compassion in your home: you see her load, you act on it, and you stay steady yourself. She deserves kindness every day, always, even when she’s at her lowest. You don’t wait for her to earn it.

The best part.

Our saying has a second half: “You can be the best part of somebody’s day.” If you asked yourself whether you’re the best part of her day, the honest answer might be no.

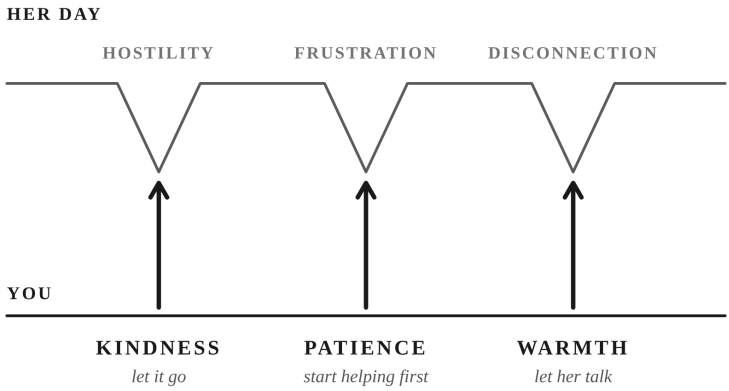
So ask yourself, each day: “Was I the best part of her day?”

For a long time I answered every zing. I should have been asking whether I was the best part of her day.

When the next zing lands, roll up your sleeves before you open your mouth.

Meet hostility with kindness, frustration with patience, disconnection with warmth

When your wife's day turns sharp



"Was I the best part of her day?"

Chapter 16

The Marriage in Flow

You know the stretch I mean. Nothing between you needs managing. Nobody is bracing for the next thing, and nobody is waiting for the other one to slip. You and your wife are in the same room because you both want to be there, and it’s easy.

That ease is what everything so far has been working toward. The calm and the strength make it possible, and the warmth is what makes it easy.

Part I was the River: staying calm when things change. That calm keeps a hard week from turning into a fight with your wife. Part II was the Oak: the strength to carry weight, so she can lean on you when life gets heavy. Part III is the Sun, and this chapter is where the three come together. The warmth you bring her is what the calm and the strength were for. It’s the capstone, the piece that sits on top of everything you’ve done so far.

The calm and the strength can feel like the hard part, and they are. But if you have both and still keep your warmth from her, you’ve done the work and she misses the best of it. Your attention and your joy are what she actually gets to live with every day.

The old picture.

A lot of us grew up with a different idea of what a man is. Men were fearless protectors and providers. You can respect that, and I do. The trouble was that it left a man nowhere to put what he felt. A lot of men I’ve known said nothing about their feelings and only spoke up to make a demand. If a man was pushed to the edge, the old picture said it was okay for him to blow up.

Calm was my first fix for that, and calm can go cold. In Chapter 1, my calm went cold and I said nothing. Another time, my cold calm came out in words, said straight to my wife.

I'd just gotten into Stoicism. We had an argument. She was angry, and I sat there quiet. When she was done, I said, "I can't control you. I can only control me and I don't see things the way you do."

She answered right away.

"If I have a man who doesn't care how I feel, if I have a man who believes that he's in a relationship by himself, then he will find himself in a relationship by himself."

She didn't want to be married to a stone.

Saying "I can't control you" carried a smug superiority, as if staying calm made me better than her. "I can only control me" is true. In that argument, I used it to opt out of what she was feeling. It should be a mindset, not something that you repeat out loud to her.

What fixed it was turning toward her.

Toward her.

Compassion is where warmth starts. Chapter 2 drew the line between feeling her mood and becoming it. You can feel compassion for somebody without taking on their emotions. Then you go to her. You sit down next to her and ask what's going on.

I think compassion is a much stronger word than it sounds. It means you want her out of the upset and the worry. You want her in her highest state, at her best, and you put your effort into helping her get there. My wife craves

connection, and I crave connection with her. Compassion is how you reach her.

Reaching her is usually small. You put the phone down when she starts talking. You notice she's tired before she has to say so, and you take something off her plate. All it takes is caring how she's doing.

The way I read the Stoics, nothing is good in itself except virtue, which means the quality of your own character. The things outside it that you hope for are what Chapter 2 called preferred indifferents. They don't decide who you are. Her happiness is one of those things. *Indifferent* doesn't mean you don't care. I want my wife happy.

I'd like to conduct myself in a way that makes our marriage stronger, my wife happier, and helps us get towards eudaimonia. Eudaimonia is the Greek word for a life that's going well as a whole. It's often translated as flourishing.

Every act of compassion you carry out is a gift to your marriage.

Both of you.

As I see it, a relationship is an investment, not a burden. She wants to know the time you give her is time you're glad to give.

I teach my boys that every kind of relationship, not just marriage, is one you build over a long period of time. I tell them it's true with their teachers, with their coaches, with their girlfriends. It's true for you, too, and most of all with your wife.

Chapter 6 brought in the Roman Stoic teacher Musonius Rufus, who described marriage as one shared life. I picture that life as a place the two of you own and live in every day. At the start of this book, I said a house can be structurally sound and still feel cold. The calm and the strength make it sound. The warmth makes it a home.

Even a warm place takes damage. Some of it is wear and tear from just living there. Some of it comes from the seasons. Some comes from the parties you throw and the guests who don't take care of the place. That's what happens to a place people actually use.

Your marriage takes those costs too. Some years one of your jobs has to come first. You each come from a family, and both sides need time and patience. Someone's health takes a turn. The kids need more than either of you planned on. None of that is anyone's fault, and every one of them takes something out of the marriage.

That's why you keep investing in it. You don't wait until something is broken. You put in all along, including the weeks when nothing seems wrong.

Some of it is small. I say good morning to her when I'm traveling. I make the coffee. I rub her back. I pick up a gift while I'm out because I thought of her. Yours will be different from mine. You know what she'd notice. What makes it matter is that you did it on an ordinary day, without being asked.

Small acts of service are only part of it. The other part is showing up in the places where she knows you're with her. Remembering the dates that matter to her is one of them. Many men find anniversaries and special days hard to remember. So have a system. Write them down, in your phone or on a calendar, somewhere you'll see them in time. If you haven't done that, you haven't really thought about your investing strategy.

She wants to know she's a priority to you, and that you're in this with her. She doesn't want to ride along as a passenger in your life. She doesn't want a marriage where you're just two people sharing an address.

She looks after the place too, in her own ways. When she feels your attention, it's easier for her to give hers. When you feel hers, it's easier for you. Two people who keep putting in make it lighter for each other to keep going.

You still go first. You put in whether or not she has much to give that week. The marriage is yours too, and looking after it is your job as much as hers. As I said in Chapter 12, my grandfather told me: “Put your wife first.”

So ask yourself about the life you share. Is it better now than it was a year ago?

In flow.

When all of this is working, the whole marriage feels different. There’s a word for this you may have heard at work: flow. You’ve seen *flow* before in this book. In the Introduction and Part I, it belonged to the River, as the way you keep going when life changes. Here it belongs to the whole marriage, the two of you working together.

The psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi described flow in his 1990 book *Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience*. He wrote about being absorbed in something that stretches you without overwhelming you. You stop watching yourself, and the doing becomes its own reward.

My sense of the word is simpler. To me, flow is when everything is going well: you’re at peace, and you’re at your best. Applying that to a whole marriage is my idea, not his. So is pairing it with three words, two of them Greek terms the Stoics used. To me, they describe what flow looks like for the two of you.

The first word is one you already know. Staying calm and steady on the inside is what Chapter 1 called equanimity. For one person, equanimity means you’re at peace. Your marriage can be at peace too, with two steady people in it. Then a hard day can be hard without becoming a fight.

The second word is new to this book, but you’ve used the idea since Chapter 1. There’s a best version of you, and a best version of your marriage. Each is

the version you'd be proud of. The Greek word for excellence is arête. It's the word behind the question Chapter 1 asked: was I being the best husband I could be? The four things you checked there, being logical, kind, self-controlled and brave enough to stay engaged, are its parts. For the Stoics, arête was excellence of character, the virtue I mentioned earlier, and it starts with the man. Arête, for a marriage, is the marriage at its best.

The third is eudaimonia, the flourishing from earlier: a life going well as a whole, over years, with both of you in it.

Each word comes from one part of the work. The calm you learned in Part I is what lets a marriage stay at peace. The strength from Part II, keeping your word and carrying weight, is part of what puts it at its best. The warmth in this part is what makes it a life she's glad to share with you. When you're calm and strong and loving at once, the calm, the strength and the warmth stop being separate jobs.

All three words are about the marriage. Being happy as an individual is very different from being happy in a relationship. Your marriage is its own living thing, with its own health, separate from you. A lot of people get confused on that. They look at the marriage as an extension of themselves, and it isn't one.

I heard a line once that I've always loved. The biggest problem in any relationship is that it has another person in it. That person is different from you, and you can't control them. It makes me laugh every time, because it's true. It's also why the marriage needs its own care. There are two of you in it, so what's good for you alone won't keep it healthy. You make it a priority, and you take care of it. Your peace counts, and so does hers.

A marriage is one home the two of you build and keep up together. Keep it at peace, at its best, and flourishing, and it moves into flow.

When your marriage is in flow, the place you share is warm and in order. Most of what that looks like is ordinary. I feel deep joy and deep love for my wife. There's nothing I want to do more than to just hang out with her. I love walking the block with her. I love going to the movies with her. On a regular weekday, that's the whole plan. She's my best friend.

I want my wife to be loved. I want her to feel desired. I want her to feel like a priority. That's what the warmth is for. Your wife should feel all of that from you, on the days nothing special is happening.

You have a lot of people in your life who need you to show up for them. Your kids. Your parents. Your siblings. The people you work with. Your wife. Every one of those relationships matters, and you should be generous with all of them.

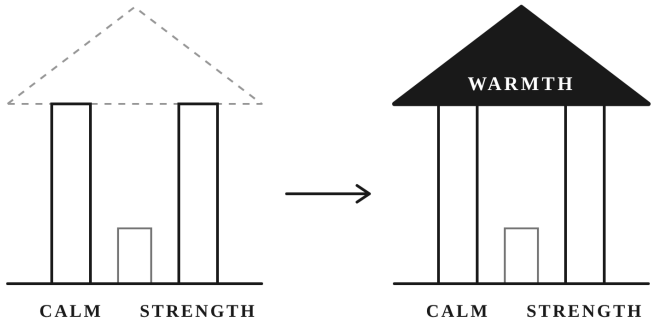
Put the most into your marriage, because she is your number one.

Calm and strength make the marriage sound; warmth makes it a home

Warmth is what the calm and the strength were for

calm alone can go cold

small, warm things



structurally sound

a home

At peace, at its best, and flourishing